

peace offering for missing out. Whether it's a straight "no" or a "no, but . . ." you haven't sacrificed your entire relationship and value for your extended family. You've just moved to care for yourself in the way that matters most right now, while continuing to tolerate the pieces that may frustrate you but you can handle. It doesn't mean you can't address more in the future, but it does allow you to pinpoint what's most important and solve for that thing, head-on.

And if just reading that example script brought up feelings of anxiety or discomfort for you, pay attention to those feelings! They are telling you something. It may mean you need to practice communicating boundaries with others on a smaller scale where the stakes are lower, like some of the examples we will give in the next subsections. It may also mean that you need to role-play your own script with trusted people until you feel comfortable with your words before communicating your decisions. We recognize this is no easy task, but the more you advocate for yourself while valuing others, the better off your life and finances will be!

With Our Friends

A lot of impulse spending with friends is the result of not wanting to miss out. Events, concerts, restaurants, activities, and trips are all FUN! We rarely want to say no to an invite because we both *need* to be around people and we *want* to experience cool things. But we've found separating the mindless spending from the core need can help shed light on what we really want. This gives room for creativity and finding alternatives that may be more conducive for our spending plan.

When you go out to dinner with friends, is it the plated blackened chicken and hummus platter hand-delivered to your table with two rounds of beverages that you value or is it the uninterrupted time spent with the friends catching up? If it's both, can you currently afford both? If not, is there a way you can get creative with how you meet your highest priority value? If you're a foodie and it really is about the food at the restaurant, then eat away! If it's about the friend, offer to host, meet at a park, host a potluck, or enjoy a free event together. We're not saying to never go out to eat with friends. We are saying sometimes we spend in ways that don't actually get us what we truly want. And when our income is not unlimited,